

Safe Motherhood

You are the first link to care for pregnant women and new mothers. Identify, counsel, refer and follow up. Your home visits do not replace antenatal visits at the health facility.

For health workers

Key messages

- Identify pregnant women in your area. Signs are a missed period, bigger breasts and darker nipples, feeling sick, passing urine often, and a growing belly. Create awareness and refer her to the facility to confirm, and keep it confidential.
- Encourage at least four ANC visits. Your monthly home visits do not count as ANC. Only a midwife, nurse, doctor or CHW at the facility or an outreach clinic can do ANC.
- Ask what stops her from going: no money for transport, distance, a bad past experience, nowhere to stay, or a family

that does not support her. Work with the family and the ward health committee on solutions.

- At home visits, look at her Helt Buk Bilong Ol Meri: due date (40 weeks after her last period), weight, blood pressure, iron and folic acid tablets, and tests done.
- Support the ANC care package: iron and folic acid, two tetanus doses, malaria prevention medicine (Fansidar, three doses at least a month apart from the second trimester), a bed net, and testing for HIV, syphilis and TB.
- Help every family make a birth plan: birth at the facility, transport and its cost, who goes with her, what to take (blanket, towel, clothes for mother and baby), and when to move near the facility.
- Check for danger signs at every monthly visit and refer urgently.
- After the birth, encourage postnatal checks on day 1, 3, 7 and 14 and at 6 weeks. Support breastfeeding within the first 90 minutes and only breast milk for six months.

Refer urgently if she has

- Any vaginal bleeding in pregnancy, or heavy bleeding after birth
- Severe headache, blurred vision, fits, or sudden swelling of face, fingers, legs or feet
- Fever or a very hot body
- Baby moving much less or not at all
- Severe belly pain, or vomiting in late pregnancy
- Waters leaking, or labour pains before the due date
- After birth: smelly vaginal discharge, lasting belly pain, breast pain or swelling
- After birth: fits, or she is withdrawn and not interested in her baby

Work with the community

- Help the ward health committee arrange transport for pregnant women, and an emergency fund.
- Talk with husbands and elders so families support ANC and birth at the facility.

- Keep all information about women private.

Run a village session

- 1.** Meet in a shaded, central place at a time when families can come. Greet everyone and say what today's topic is.
- 2.** Ask what people already know and what they have heard. Listen first.
- 3.** Share three key messages from this page in your local language. Use pictures and real examples from the village.
- 4.** Ask people to say the messages back in their own words, and answer questions.
- 5.** Agree on one action the village will take this month. Refer anyone who is unwell, and record who came.

General information only. Follow the advice of your health centre and current national guidelines. Based on the National Department of Health Village Health Assistant (VHA) training curriculum.